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More than 170,000 acres in Midwest national forests, including Shawnee, could be opened to roads, logging and mining under Trump plan



‘WE STAND TO LOSE OUR SOLITUDE’

By Christiana Freitag | FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

For 73-year-old Harold “Cricket” Simons, a major appeal of the Shawnee National Forest is what isn’t there.

No motorized vehicles. No traffic passing on most trails. No horns or engines breaking the quiet.

Simons travels through the forest on horseback. The former Bloomington, Illinois, rodeo rider spends much of his retirement leading the Illinois chapter of the Back Country Horsemen of America, a national organization of horse-riding volunteers who help maintain trails and public lands.

His five horses are accustomed to the sounds of trail work: the occasional chainsaw or falling tree.

But he said his workhorses, like him, prefer silence.

That’s at risk as the Trump administration’s Department of Agriculture proposed in August to repeal a 2001 federal rule restricting road construction on national forest lands.

“We stand to lose our solitude in our roadless areas,” Simons said.

The repeal of the conservation regulation commonly known as the Roadless Rule, would affect nearly 45 million acres of national forests across the country, including about 10,666 acres in Shawnee.

Across the Midwest, more than 170,000 acres of public lands are protected under the Roadless Rule, including portions of Indiana’s Hoosier National Forest, Minnesota’s Superior and Chippewa national forests and Michigan’s Ottawa and Huron-Manistee national forests.

The proposal is drawing concern from horseback riders like Simons and hunters, hikers and other outdoor recreationists, as well as tribal groups with treaty rights across the Great Lakes region. Conservationists worry that numerous threatened and endangered species will be adversely affected.

“There’s a lot to lose here, and everybody needs to be made aware of it,” said Kelly Thayer, senior policy advocate with the Environmental Law & Policy Center.

The proposed repeal comes as the U.S. Forest Service is also contending with other changes to federal forest management policy, Thayer said,

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Above: Harold “Cricket” Simons clears a log from a trail in Shawnee National Forest in Illinois on Sept. 21.

E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

ELECTION 2026
U.S. SENATE

Long odds for GOP’s Tracy

The Republican nominee is facing a big political challenge against Stratton

By Olivia Olander
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Addressing supporters at an evening fundraiser off Lake Decatur in July, Republican U.S. Senate nominee Don Tracy offered one reason he thinks he has a shot in the general election, despite Democrats winning every statewide contest for more than a decade.

“I hear this question up and down the state, ‘Don, who is your opponent?’” Tracy said. “I answer that, and I say, ‘Well, my opponent is the lieutenant governor. Do you know his or her name?’ Nobody knows.”

But then he pivoted almost immediately.

“Granted, she has more name ID than I do, so far,” Tracy said. “But it’s not that much more.”

Such is the political challenge for Tracy, a candidate for a statewide office with a unique background — a onetime Democrat who became chair of the Illinois Republican Party, a position he later left amid party turmoil. Nonetheless, he has taken up the GOP mantle to make a long-shot Senate bid.



Tracy

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INSIDE

Co-pilot used ax in attack, UAE says

The co-pilot was an Omani national who had been barred from flying on his country’s airline. **Nation & World, Page B5**

Relive the legend of singer-songwriter

The celebrations for what would have been John Prine’s 80th birthday will be lavish and music-filled. **Arts & Entertainment**

Many want an office, just not a conventional one

Chicagoans needing place to work set up in co-working spaces

By Lila Hempel-Edgers
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

By the time he’s halfway up a climbing wall, Emerson Boyd is thinking only about which colorful nub might best carry his weight. For a few minutes, he’s beyond the reach of incoming emails — a freedom that’s hard to come by in the middle of a workday.

“Everyone here is doing their own thing, but they’re all working toward some goal that they have,” said the 29-year-old software developer, who co-works from First Ascent in the Loop. “The variety is good.”

Boyd is part of a growing contra-

diction in Chicago, a city that simultaneously boasts the nation’s second-largest co-working market and some of the highest office vacancy rates in the country. The disparity suggests workers might be looking for something more than a quiet cubicle.

Industry experts say Chicagoans are setting up laptops in spaces that double as climbing gyms and dog parks, trading subsidized parking for culinary classes and on-site podcast studios. Many still need a place to work, but the appeal of the conventional office has soured alongside the work-from-home routine they didn’t ask for.

“What people want in an office building has changed,” said Sean Boyd, who manages Avison Young’s market intelligence team. “But the



Hayden Golemon, 27, climbs at First Ascent climbing gym at Block 37 in downtown Chicago on Thursday. Golemon uses the gym regularly to both work and climb during the week. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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